Think of it as an Uttar Pradesh within an Uttar Pradesh. The perfect microcosm. Except in the cardinal direction it marks out—the east, rather than the north—Purvanchal is for UP what UP is for India. It would report a high match on almost all other parameters. Especially in terms of that ironic equation: it's the poorer part, yet the one that holds the decisive casting vote over the whole. If a sovereign command over UP tilts the power balance in India, the victor in the Bhojpuri-speaking eastern belt may well get to hold that sceptre in Lucknow. The 19 districts that vote in the last two phases of an epic election hold approximately a total population of 35 million—enough to rival any East European nation on their own—but they are formed in an intricately patterned social mosaic. That creates its own dynamics, but there's a fluidity at the micro level too. And if the larger battle is still poised as a wide open game, one that can go any which way, it's reflected in how the individual voter reads the polls: there's an ambiguity, a sense of certitudes shaken by surrounding change.

Take the words of Nand Kumar, of Mundera Bazar in Gorakhpur. The 53-year-old has come to attend a Yogi Adityanath roadshow—it's Monday, February 28, and voting is just two days away in the chief minister's home base. If anything, it should have been all sewn up. Perhaps it is. "*Baba hi jitiye* (Yogi will win)," says Nand Kumar. But there's an iffiness in his tone, at least about the overall scenario in UP. Reason? His 24-year-old son, Awadesh, did not accompany him. Instead, he had chosen to attend Akhilesh Yadav's roadshow in the town area on Saturday. "We support Maharaj-*ji*," indicating himself and his wife, "but the new generation in my family is in favour of Akhilesh." He will not hazard a guess about the final tally. No one who witnessed the two roadshows wants to be in the game of predicting outcomes. Both events were fully packed. Purvanchal is proving to be quite the climax: experientially at least, it feels like a tense tie-breaker.

Both parties, the BJP and the Samajwadi Party (SP), claim the upper hand after the first five phases. Whichever one is right, the 111 seats of Purvanchal present such a complex challenge that prior advantage may be of no avail. The numerical game here is of a qualitatively different sort. Politics in UP's western and central provinces is marked by the dominance of specific castes and communities in a majority of seats. The electoral equations here, on the other hand, present a far more complicated picture. There is a whole archipelago of non-elite castes dominating pockets across this swathe—especially non-Yadav OBCs and non-Jatav Dalits. Just that former segment numbers nearly 8 million. How many of them the smaller caste-based outfits manage to attract, therefore, will be critical to the success of the bigger parties. The bigger parties have rushed to make alliances with parties that claim the affiliation of communities like the Rajbhars, Kurmis, Mauryas, Pasis, Nishads and Nonias. It's a marker of political evolution, in a way—of power being federated.

THE POWER BACKUP

The ruling BJP has the support of the Apna Dal (S) and Nishad Party. The former, led by Union minister and Mirzapur MP Anupriya Patel, has a strong hold among Kurmis, only 2.7 million-odd in all, but above 9 per cent of the electorate in these parts—which makes them the second largest chunk of OBCs after Yadavs, who too are nearly 5 million here. Anupriya's Apna Dal is contesting from 17 seats, but its proprietary hold over Kurmis is challenged by the Apna Dal (K) faction, led by her mother Krishna Patel, which is part of the Samajwadi Party alliance. The Nishad Party, which claims a command over the riverine fishing community in this Gangetic belt (comprising 22 subcastes), is contesting from 16 seats. The fragmented community map of eastern UP enables the Nishads to punch above their weight too—especially because they have 10-plus per cent population concentration in over half a dozen districts here, including Gorakhpur, Kushinagar and Varanasi.

The Samajwadi Party has on its side two small parties that are offering a crucial counter-balance. The Suheldev Bharatiya Samaj Party (SBSP) of O.P. Rajbhar is the main name here. The Rajbhars form only 4 per cent of the population in UP, but they too constitute 12-22 per cent of the electorate in several districts in Purvanchal, especially in Azamgarh, Jaunpur, Mau, Ballia, Ghazipur and Varanasi. That makes them a decisive element in over 25 seats. The Janvadi Party (Socialist) wields influence over the traditionally salt-making Nonia/ Lonia/ Lunia community—again, they are only 2 per cent of UP's total population, but form 10-15 per cent of the electorate in several eastern districts, including Chandauli, Mau, Ghazipur and Ballia.

The SP has also fielded heavyweight OBC leader Swami Prasad Maurya from Fazil Nagar seat of Kushinagar. A former minister in Yogi Adityanath's government and an influential Maurya community leader, his switch to the Akhilesh camp was touted as a self-fulfilling prophecy—both a signal and a catalyst



WHO STANDS WHERE

BJP SP BSP Congress Others

Leaders to watch: Yogi Adityanath (BJP), Om Prakash Rajbhar (SBSP), Anupriya Patel (Apna Dal-S), Sanjay Nishad (Nishad Party), Swami Prasad Maurya (SP), Ajay Lallu (Cong.), Dara Singh Chauhan (SP), Abbas Ansari (SBSP)

Graphic by ASIT ROY